alive among a small circle of scholars in traditional educational institutions. It is the work of British archaeologists and palaeographists that revived memories of ancient Indian empires, deciphered King Ashoka's rock inscriptions, translated ancient texts and spurred the revival of Buddhism. The harking back to a glorious past was part of the nationalistic response both in China and in India, but in India the medium to a large extent was the English language.

Religion played an important role in mobilizing nationalist sentiment in India. Political leaders like Bal Gangadhar Tilak and even Mahatma Gandhi infused the nationalist movement with a strong religious flavour. In China, religion played virtually no part in the nationalist response to the Western challenge, despite the strong influence of Buddhism among the people. The revival of Confucian norms was certainly part of the movement, but more as a set of ethical principles rather than as a religious faith.

In India, despite its diversity, Indian nationalism was able to provide an overarching and unifying narrative, which transcended differences in languages, traditions, patterns of living and even religious faith. This was truly a pan-Indian movement. In China, nationalism was limited to the majority ethnic group of the Hans. There was no participation by the country's other ethnic groups such as the Manchus, the Tibetans, the Mongols and the Muslim communities in the west.

Independent India retained the governing institutions and processes put in place by the British colonial government, and this ensured a relatively smooth transition from colony to sovereign state. In China, the Marxist–Leninist state which came into existence in 1949 represented a clear break from the past. The Chinese doubted whether India had truly become independent when Mountbatten was retained as Governor General of India after 1947 and both the civil services and the armed forces of the colonial government continued to function with little change. These differences played an important role in shaping Chinese perceptions of India. Though there was mutual sympathy between the peoples of the two countries for their respective struggles against Western imperialism and colonial rule, China's world view did not accord a position of equality to India as a force